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IN CONCERT
Prime Minister Narendra Modi addressing a rally in Chittorgarh on Oct. 2, (below) Union home minister Amit Shah

BATTLE FOR RAJASTHAN

DOUBLE ENGINE DESERT BLITZ

By Rohit Parihar

It became New Delhi versus Jaipur in poll-bound Rajasthan, with Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Union home minister Amit Shah leading the Bharatiya Janata Party's (BJP) charge against Congress chief minister Ashok Gehlot. On October 2, Modi landed in Chittorgarh to unveil development projects worth Rs 7,000 crore. This was his second visit to the state in just over a week.

If Modi was back in the thick of things after a two-month hiatus with a massive rally in Jaipur on September 25, Shah was also in the state capital, along with BJP national president J.P. Nadda, two days later to hold talks with state-level senior leaders.

Trying hard to take along the many factions, the BJP is yet to come out with its first list of candidates in Rajasthan. Party insiders say that Shah has now been tasked with ironing out differences and finalising the names. On September 27, he and Nadda were busy holding meetings till late past midnight, with another round early in the morning, before flying back to Delhi.

Those who met the two senior BJP leaders say that Shah, true to himself, was very blunt in his assessment and comments, for instance, about the poor turnout at the month-long 'parivartan yatras'. (The only high point of this otherwise lacklustre 'campaign for change' came with Modi's Jaipur rally that brought down the curtains on it.) Shah is also said to have indicated that the party will be giving tickets to fresh faces and parliamentarians, dashing the hopes of some veterans, who have apparently been told to concentrate on ensuring the BJP's win rather than entering the fray themselves.

Meanwhile, happy with the turnout at the Jaipur event, Modi will be barnstorming down the state, with half a dozen more rallies slated in October. Amid lingering suspense over the chief ministerial face, Modi has refrained from giving away much at his rallies, insisting that the BJP symbol 'lotus' remains the party's lone face. In effect, these rallies are an attempt to convince the electorate that in voting for the BJP and not for any specific CM face, they are voting for the Modi brand of governance in Rajasthan.

What adds to the suspense is the choice of rally venues. If Chittorgarh is represented in the Lok Sabha by state BJP president C.P. Joshi, the PM will also be visiting Jodhpur, the constituency of another party heavyweight and CM hopeful—Union minister Gajendra Singh Shekhawat. One of the rallies is also likely to take place in Kota, the hometown of Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla, whose backing got Joshi the president's post. Now, both are in the race for the CM's seat if the BJP wins.

In another interesting development, soon after Shah's visit, the BJP welcomed back Devi Singh Bhati, an influential Rajput leader, into the party fold. Not so long ago, Union minister Arjun Ram Meghwal—another CM hopeful—had vehemently opposed the move, being pushed by former CM Vasundhara Raje. So, is Raje, who also shared the stage with Modi at both his Jaipur and Chittorgarh rallies, back in the reckoning? ■

PM MODI WILL BE THE BJP'S FACE, SHAH WILL FINALISE THE LIST OF CANDIDATES